

FROM MICHAEL FLOURNOY · GSD ASSOCIATES

The VP of Sales Playbook

How I helped grow Whip Around from 4 people in a WeWork to a \$100M acquisition — and the exact playbook I now bring to B2B SaaS companies stuck between \$1M and \$10M ARR.

Michael Flournoy

Founder & Fractional VP of Sales · GSD Associates

gsdassociates.net

THE ORIGIN STORY

4 People. One WeWork. Zero Revenue.

In 2018, I joined a fleet management SaaS company called Whip Around. They were based in New Zealand. Nobody in America had heard of them. I was one of four people tasked with building the entire US operation from scratch.

We had nothing. No clients. No brand. No sales playbook. No safety net. Just a shared WeWork office, a product we believed in, and a mandate to win.

I built the discovery framework. The outbound machine. The coaching cadence. The pipeline discipline. The hiring criteria. The onboarding process for new reps. We documented everything, tested everything, and iterated relentlessly. Every system in this playbook was forged in the field — not in a consulting deck.

The result: Whip Around was acquired for \$100 million.

***"We were 4 people in a WeWork with zero revenue.
Then we built the machine. These 10 systems are
how we did it."***

— Michael Flourney, Founder, GSD Associates

I now bring this exact playbook to B2B SaaS companies stuck between \$1M and \$10M ARR. Companies that have product-market fit but can't figure out why revenue isn't growing. Companies that hired a VP of Sales and it didn't work. Companies that need someone who has actually done it before.

This playbook is what I hand to every client on day one. It's not theory. Every word comes from doing the work.

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Build the System Before You Scale the Team

The biggest mistake growing B2B companies make: adding headcount before building process.

Here's how it plays out. Revenue stalls. The founder hires two or three salespeople. Those reps improvise because no playbook exists. Pipeline gets messy. Close rates drop. Revenue stays flat.

The fix is almost never more people. It's better systems.

At Whip Around, we spent the first three months documenting everything before making a single hire. A repeatable discovery framework. Qualification criteria with hard exit gates. A demo structure. An objection handling guide. Follow-up sequences with clear ownership.

When we finally brought reps on board, they were productive in 60 days. The industry average is six months. That gap is the system.

**ACTION
ITEM**

Before you hire your next rep, ask: Could someone walk in tomorrow and know exactly what to do on day one? If the answer is no, you don't need a hire. You need a playbook.

Discovery Is the Whole Game

If your team can't run a great discovery call, nothing downstream matters. Not the demo. Not the proposal. Not the close.

We built our entire sales motion around five diagnostic questions. These aren't tricks — they're diagnostic tools that surface real pain, real urgency, and real buying authority before you waste anyone's time.

1. "What happens if this problem isn't solved in six months?"

Creates urgency without pressure. Makes the buyer quantify the cost of inaction.

2. "Who else on your team feels this pain every day?"

Finds your real champion — the person who will fight for budget internally.

3. "What's stopped you from solving this before?"

Surfaces the real objection before you get blindsided at close.

4. "If we fixed this, what does success look like a year from now?"

The buyer paints the vision. They're selling themselves.

5. "If I could show you how to solve this in 90 days, is there anything on your side that would prevent us from moving forward?"

Flushes out blockers before the demo. No surprises.

**ACTION
ITEM**

Record your next 10 discovery calls. Score them 1–5 on each question. Anything below 3 is a coaching opportunity.

Clean Your Pipeline or It Will Kill You

A dirty pipeline is worse than no pipeline. It creates false confidence, kills forecasting accuracy, and burns your best reps on dead deals.

At Whip Around, we did a mandatory pipeline audit every Monday. Every deal had to answer three questions to stay in the forecast:

Question 1: Is there a real champion? Not the person who took the call — the person who will fight for budget when you're not in the room.

Question 2: Is there a compelling event? A deadline, a trigger, a consequence for inaction. If there isn't one, you're not in a sales cycle. You're in a conversation.

Question 3: Do you have access to the economic buyer? If your champion can't get you in the room with the person who controls the budget, the deal is slower than you think.

Deals that couldn't answer all three were moved to 'nurture' immediately. Not deleted — just removed from forecast. The result was a smaller pipeline that was 3x more accurate.

ACTION ITEM

Run your pipeline through these three questions today. Move anything that fails to nurture. Your forecast will shrink — and become real.

Coach Weekly or Don't Bother

The best VP of Sales I've ever seen spends 60% of their time on coaching. Not strategy. Not forecasting. Coaching.

At Whip Around we ran an 80-minute weekly coaching cadence for every rep. The format never changed:

15 minutes: Pipeline review — champion, compelling event, economic buyer. Any deal that can't answer all three gets moved.

30 minutes: Call review — listen to one recorded discovery call together. Score it on the 5-question framework. Identify one specific behavior to improve.

20 minutes: Skills practice — roleplay the thing they're weakest on. Not theory. Live practice.

15 minutes: Wins and next week's focus — celebrate a specific win, set one measurable goal for next week.

The reps who got this coaching every week hit quota at 2.3x the rate of reps who got sporadic coaching. That's not a coincidence.

ACTION ITEM

Block 80 minutes every week per rep on your calendar now. If your schedule can't absorb it, you have too many reps or not enough time for leadership.

Founder-Led Sales First — Always

You cannot hire your way out of a sales problem you haven't solved yourself.

I've seen this pattern dozens of times. Founder struggles to close deals. Hires a VP of Sales to solve it. VP can't close either. Founder blames the hire.

The real problem: no one knows why the first 20 customers said yes. The messaging isn't clear. The ICP isn't defined. The sales cycle isn't documented.

Before you make your first sales hire, you need to close 50 deals yourself. Not 10. Not 20. Fifty. By deal 50, you know:

- Which industries convert fastest
- Which titles have buying authority
- Which objections come up every time
- What makes a great discovery question land
- How long the real sales cycle is (not the optimistic one)

At Whip Around, I personally worked the first 60 accounts before we hired our first AE. When she started, I could hand her a playbook with real data. She hit quota in month two.

**ACTION
ITEM**

If you have fewer than 50 closed deals and are considering a sales hire, pause. Close 50 first. Document everything. Then hire.

The Hiring Framework That Actually Works

The \$200K VP of Sales is the most expensive mistake a \$1–3M ARR company can make.

Here's the problem with hiring a senior VP early: they're optimized for managing a team, not building one. They've been handed a playbook, a quota, and a CRM. They've never built anything from scratch.

What you need at \$1–3M ARR is a **builder**, not a manager. Someone who can:

- Close deals themselves (not just oversee others)
- Document what works and turn it into a process
- Hire and onboard one or two junior reps
- Report metrics in a way that drives decisions

The interview test we used at Whip Around for every sales hire: **"Sell me Whip Around right now."** Not the product — the company. The vision. The why. If they can't do it cold with no prep, they won't do it to a customer with pressure.

The second test: **"What's your process for the first 30 days?"** Listen for specifics. Vague answers mean they're winging it.

ACTION ITEM

Write your ideal '30-60-90 day plan' for your next sales hire before you interview anyone. If you can't articulate what success looks like in 90 days, you're not ready to hire.

Outbound Wins: Why Waiting for Inbound Is a Losing Strategy

At \$1–2M ARR, you don't have enough brand recognition for inbound to work at scale. Outbound is the only lever you fully control.

At Whip Around, we ran a three-touch outbound system that drove 40% of our new business in year one. The model was simple, but most companies get it wrong by being too clever.

Touch 1 — The Story: Lead with the Whip Around origin. '4 people. One WeWork. Zero revenue.' Specificity creates credibility. No one reads generic cold email.

Touch 2 — The Challenge Question: 'What's your biggest sales challenge right now?' Not a pitch. A question. You'd be amazed what people share when you just ask.

Touch 3 — The Breakup: 'I'll assume the timing isn't right. If that changes, I'm here.' Clean exits get replies. Aggressive follow-up doesn't.

The mistake most founders make: stopping at Touch 1 or cramming the pitch into the first email. Let the sequence breathe. Trust the process.

ACTION ITEM

Map your current outbound sequence against this framework. Are you leading with story? Are you asking a real question in Touch 2? Is your breakup clean?

The Metrics That Matter (And the Ones That Lie)

Most sales dashboards are full of vanity metrics that feel good and tell you nothing about where your revenue is going.

The metrics that actually predict revenue (the ones we tracked weekly at Whip Around):

Pipeline Coverage Ratio: Quota / pipeline value. You need 3x. If you have \$100K quota and \$200K pipeline, you're going to miss.

Stage Conversion Rates: What % of opportunities make it from stage 1 to stage 2? Stage 2 to 3? Every drop-off is a bottleneck. Fix the biggest one first.

Average Sales Cycle Length: Not your best deals — your average. Know the number, then work to compress it by 20%.

Win Rate by Source: Are you closing inbound at 35% but outbound at 12%? That's a conversation about resource allocation, not effort.

The metrics that lie: number of activities (calls made, emails sent), number of demos booked. These are inputs, not outcomes. Track outcomes.

ACTION ITEM

Pull your last 90 days of closed/lost deals. Calculate your win rate by source, by stage conversion, and average cycle length. You'll see your biggest problem immediately.

Compensation: How to Structure It So Reps Stay and Win

Bad comp plans drive away your best reps and keep your worst ones. Most companies get this wrong by accident.

The principle we used at Whip Around: **make it easy to earn, hard to coast.**

The structure that works for early-stage SaaS:

Base salary: 60–70% of OTE. High enough to attract talent, low enough to matter when variable kicks in.

Commission: Pay on annual contract value (ACV), not monthly. This incentivizes reps to push for annual contracts instead of cheap monthly agreements.

Accelerators: Above 100% of quota, commission rate doubles. This is what keeps your best rep from taking your competitor's call.

Clawback: 90-day clawback on churn. This aligns rep incentives with customer success and kills the habit of closing bad-fit accounts to hit quota.

Keep the comp plan to one page. If a rep can't calculate their paycheck in their head, the plan is too complicated.

ACTION ITEM

Put your current comp plan on one page. Can your reps calculate their expected paycheck from this week's pipeline without a spreadsheet? If not, simplify it.

How to Know When You're Ready for a Full-Time VP

Most founders hire a VP of Sales too early. A few hire too late. Here's the test.

You're ready for a full-time VP of Sales when:

- 1. You have documented, repeatable systems.** The VP should optimize a working machine — not build one from scratch. If there's no playbook, no defined ICP, no stage-exit criteria, you're not ready.
- 2. You're at \$3M+ ARR.** Below that, you probably can't afford the \$200–250K OTE a real VP commands — and the ROI math doesn't work.
- 3. You have at least 3–4 AEs to manage.** A VP managing one rep is a waste. You need scale before leadership overhead makes sense.
- 4. You've been founder-led long enough to know your ICP cold.** The VP needs to be handed a clear playbook, a defined ICP, and at least 3 months of pipeline data.

If you're not there yet, a Fractional VP of Sales is the right move. Same caliber of leadership. 30% of the cost. No full-time commitment on either side.

ACTION ITEM

Score yourself on all four criteria above. If you're missing any one of them, consider fractional leadership until you hit the threshold.

READY TO APPLY THIS TO YOUR BUSINESS?

Book a Free 30-Minute Sales Architecture Call

I'll review your current sales motion — pipeline, discovery process, sequence copy, rep structure, comp plan — and tell you exactly where the biggest leak is. No pitch. No obligation. Just the diagnosis.

calendly.com/gsdassociatesllc/30min

gsdassociates.net

Michael Flourney · Founder, GSD Associates

Former founding sales team, Whip Around (\$100M acquisition)